

Courtyard Reflections...

An Immersive Journey Through Academic Stress at UBC Okanagan

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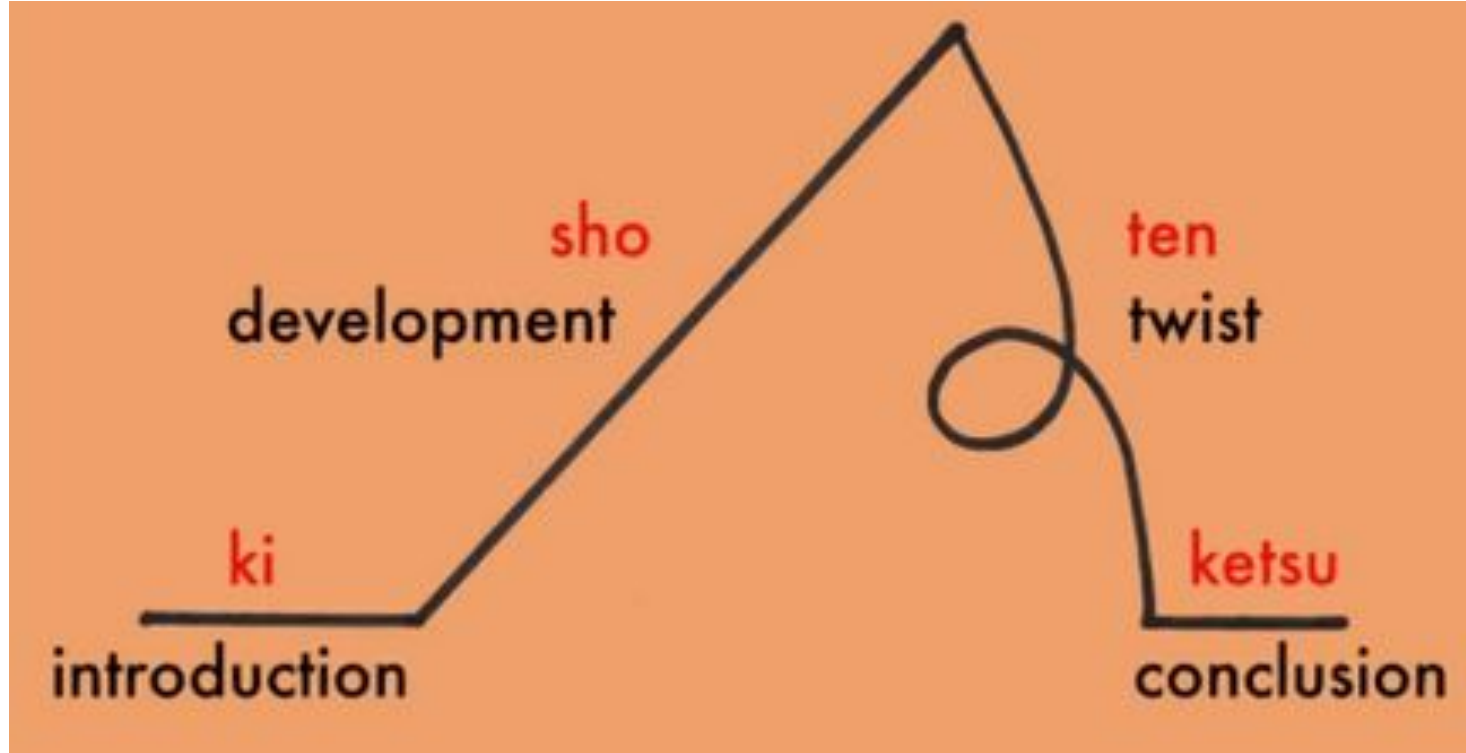


Motivation



- Rising student stress & cognitive overload
- Stress escalation is often invisible or undermined
- VR can help externalize internal struggles
- **Goal: Simulate emotional buildup → Spread awareness → Highlight Resources**

Narrative Structure: Kishōtenketsu



Ki - Act 1: A Normal Day

Scene: Intro to courtyard, ambient background, friendly NPC.

Goal: Establish comfort + introduce first stress trigger.

Design Intent: Introduce mild pressure through dialogue

Interactions:

- ❑ Dialogue with friend
- ❑ Player choice influences tone
- ❑ Notification → opens task UI → Pick tasks
- ❑ Mild environmental feedback



Shō - Act 2: Rising Pressure

Scene: Player approaches professor slightly stressed.

Goal: Demonstrate how responsibilities stack unexpectedly

Design Intent: Build tension through unavoidable commitments and role pressure.

Interactions:

- ❑ Dialogue with Professor NPC
- ❑ Receive urgent TA grading task
- ❑ Add new task to full list (forced prioritization)
- ❑ Stronger environmental feedback



Ten - Act 3: Overload

Scene: High stress → sound and visuals intensify rapidly.

Goal: Make the user feel cognitive overload and emotional collapse.

Design Intent: Translate internal stress into sensory overwhelm.

Interactions:

- ❑ Internal whispers
- ❑ Strongest environmental feedback



Ketsu - Act 4: Resolution

Scene: Resource paper in main courtyard

Goal: Provide emotional relief and direct access to support resources

Design Intent: End the experience by receiving encouragement and practical next steps

Interactions:

- ❑ A poster with UBC mental health resources appears automatically
- ❑ The final voiceover reassures user and encourages help-seeking.



Design Decisions

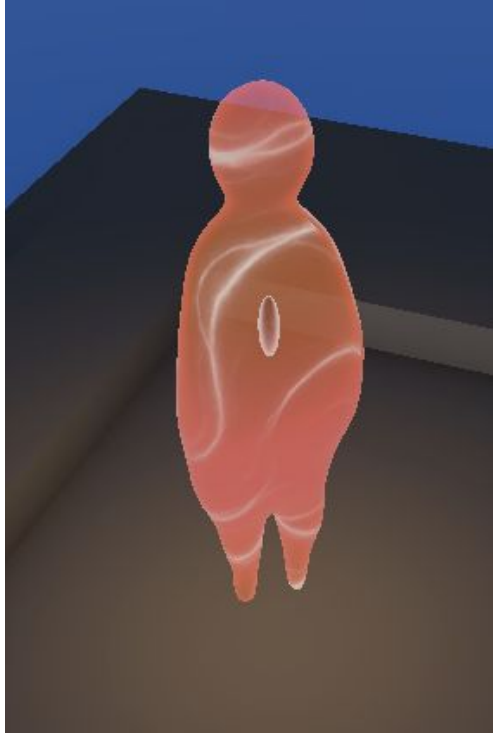
- **Gradual Emotional Escalation:** Built tension progressively to increase immersion and presence. (Slater & Wilbur, 1997)
- **Interactive Role-Play Framework:** NPC conversations and player dialogue choices create agency and emotional grounding. (Murray, 1997; Laurel, 1991)
- **Guided Emotional Trajectory:** Experience follows a controlled emotional build-up while allowing light player interaction. (Mateas & Stern, 2005).
- **Progressive Environmental Feedback Loop:** Environment shifts (sound, ambience) reflect the user's emotional progression. (Slater & Wilbur, 1997; McMahan, 2003)



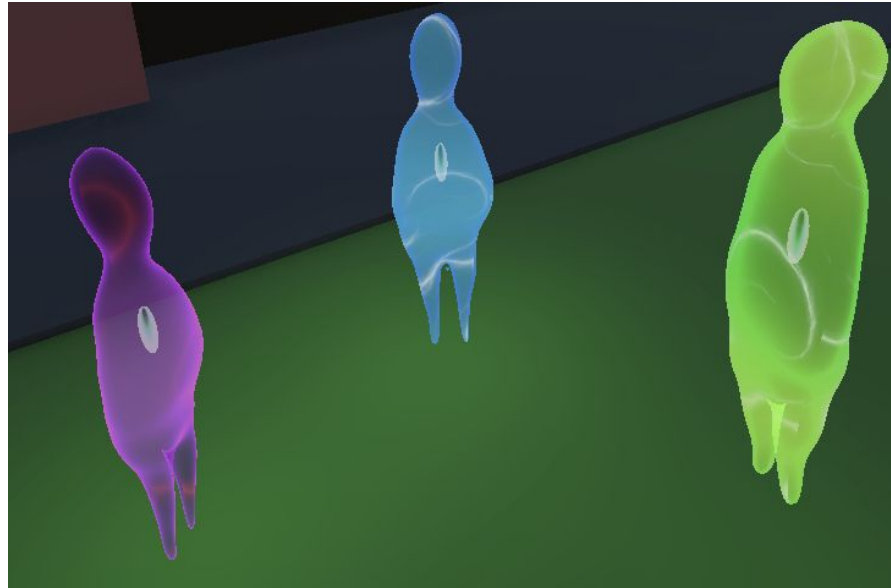
Key Features



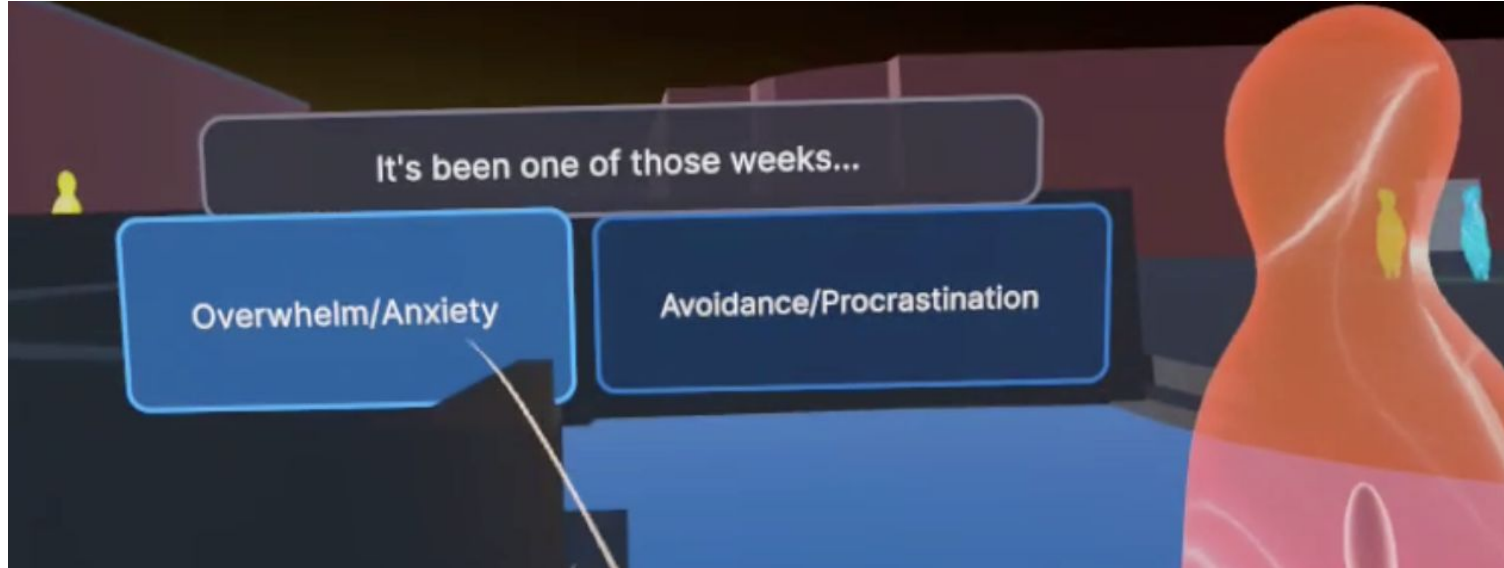
NPC Design & Interaction



- Can Interact within 3m radius
- Interactable NPCs: Red + Warm light
- Other NPCs: Various colours (represents emotional states)



Dialogue Choice UI System



- UI toolkit
- Anchored to left of NPC + faces user
- Scale & highlight on hover
- Audio-timed progression

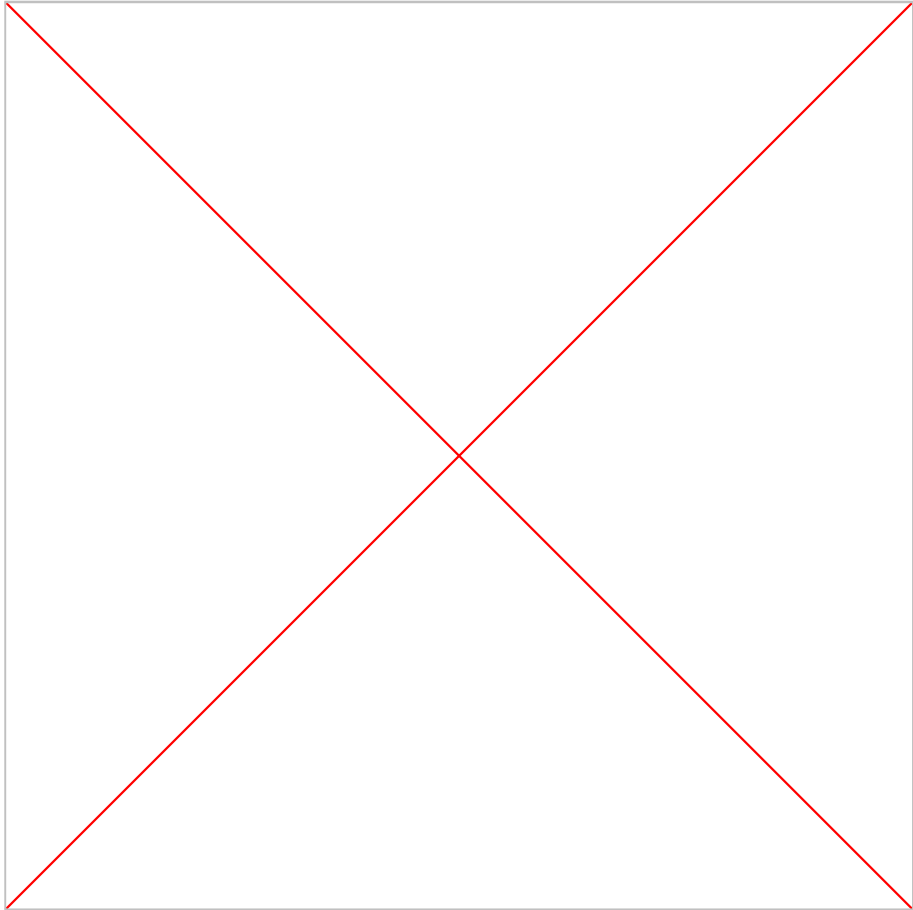
Notification + Task UI



- UI toolkit
- Anchored to main camera
- Hover effects
- Highlight on selected task



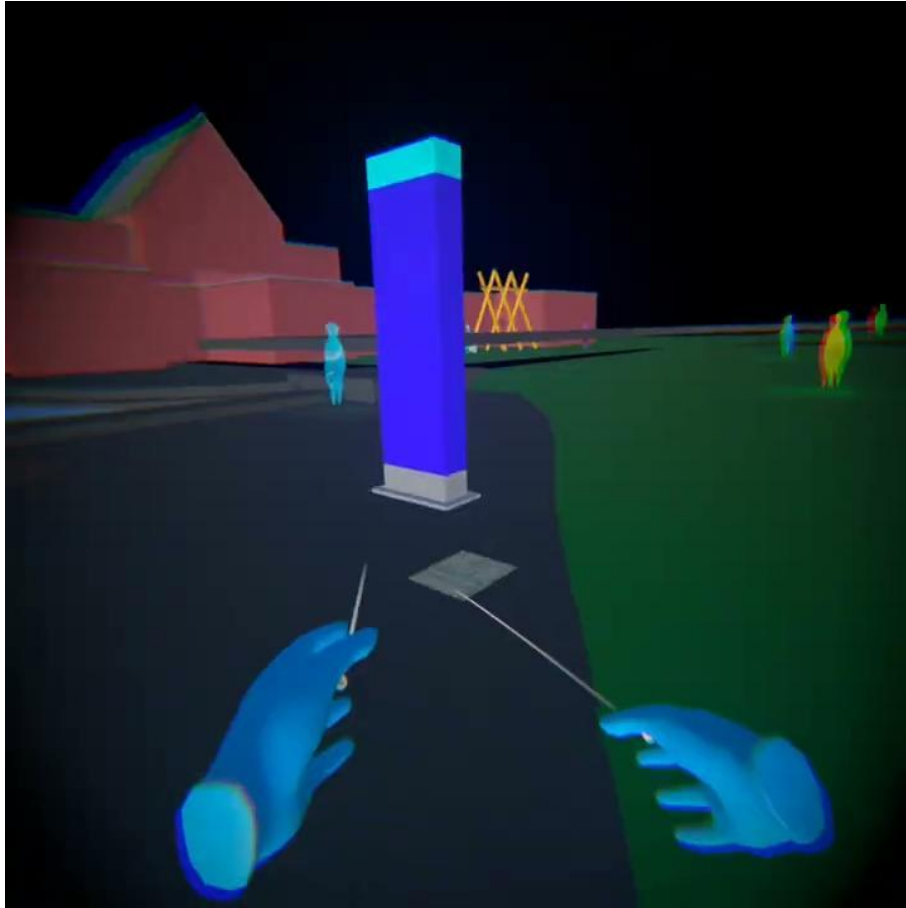
Anxiety Manager



- Vignette
- Chromatic aberration
- Film grain
- Heartbeat audio



Help & Resources Paper UI



- 3D plane + paper texture + TextMeshPro
- Scale on hover
- Anchored to main camera + smooth follow movement



References

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Backup Demo





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Thank You!

Questions?